INTERPERSONAL FALSE BELIEF #1 · PARENTS

“My parents never loved me.”

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Where it often comes from

Some of us grew up with parents who were distant, harsh, absent, addicted, or simply unable to show love in a way we could feel. Children draw their conclusions from what they experience, and a child who did not feel loved often decides, “I was unlovable,” or “they never loved me.” That conclusion can then shape friendships, marriage, and even how we imagine God.

What Scripture teaches

Scripture is honest that parents can fail. The psalmist says, “Though my father and mother forsake me, the LORD will receive me.” God is called “a father of the fatherless,” and “God settles the lonely in families.” Jeremiah records God’s words, “I have loved you with an everlasting love; therefore I have drawn you with loving devotion.” John says, “Behold what manner of love the Father has given to us, that we should be called children of God. And that is what we are!” Even if human love fell short, God’s love for you is not in question. A parent’s failure to show love is a real wound, but it is not a verdict on your worth.

> *“Though my father and mother forsake me, the LORD will receive me”* (Psalm 27:10).

Also see

> “The LORD appeared to us in the past, saying: ‘I have loved you with an everlasting love; therefore I have drawn you with loving devotion.’” (Jeremiah 31:3).

> “A father of the fatherless, and a defender of the widows, is God in His holy habitation. God settles the lonely in families; He leads the prisoners out to prosperity, but the rebellious dwell in a sun-scorched land” (Psalm 68:5–6).

> “Behold what manner of love the Father has given to us, that we should be called children of God. And that is what we are! The reason the world does not know us is that it did not know Him” (1 John 3:1).

> “For I am convinced that neither death nor life, neither angels nor principalities, neither the present nor the future, nor any powers, neither height nor depth, nor anything else in all creation, will be able to separate us from the love of God that is in Christ Jesus our Lord” (Romans 8:38–39).

Common self-statements

- I was never wanted.
- There must be something wrong with me or they would have loved me.
- No one will ever love me the way a parent should.
- I do not matter to the people who should care most.
- Love is for other people.
- I will always feel unloved.

Common logical errors

- Emotional reasoning: Feeling unloved and concluding that I was and am unlovable.
- Personalization: Believing their failure to love was caused by something wrong in me.
- All-or-nothing thinking: Seeing parents as either fully loving or never loving at all.
- Overgeneralizing: Letting one painful relationship define all love.

Challenging questions

- What did I actually experience from my parents, and what conclusions did I draw as a child?
- Were there any moments, however small, when I was cared for?
- What might have been going on in my parents that kept them from loving well?
- Is a parent's inability to love the same as my being unlovable?
- What does God say about how He sees me?
- Who in my life now shows me love?

Truth summary

> My parents' failure to love me well was real and painful, but it does not define my worth. God has loved me with an everlasting love, and He receives me as His child. I can grieve what I missed and receive what God and His people offer now.

Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

- Love, By God
- Loneliness
- Parenting
- Self-Esteem, Low
- God, All Loving

Godly Counsel Lessons:

From the book *Godly Counsel* by Dr. Brian Campbell. Click a lesson to open it. You can read it on screen or print it.

- Self-Esteem, Low
- Love

Listen: Overcoming Depression

> Overcoming Depression · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 20 minutes

Songs that speak truth to this belief

The God Who Stays — Matthew West
God's faithful presence challenges the expectation of rejection and abandonment.

He Knows — Jeremy Camp
Jesus understands suffering and invites people to bring their burdens to Him.

Who Am I — Casting Crowns
Being known and cared for by God rests on His love rather than personal importance.

Jesus Loves Me — Gaither Vocal Band
This familiar hymn places confidence in Jesus' love rather than personal strength.

Each morning ask: "If I truly believed God's truth instead of this lie, how would I think, speak, and act today?"

HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

My Plan for Replacing "My parents never loved me"

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Read through each section and check the one that fits you best. If none of them fit, write your own. One choice per section is enough. A truth you choose for yourself will stick better than one handed to you.

Name: _____ Date started: _____

1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

Rate it now so you can see your progress later.

"My parents never loved me." I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

2 My best question

The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.

- ☐ What did I experience from my parents?
- ☐ What conclusions did I draw as a child?
- ☐ Who loves me now?
- ☐ What does God say about me?
- ☐ What do I need to grieve?
- ☐ Who can I talk with about this?

My own question: _____

3 My replacement truth

The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.

- ☐ My worth is not decided by how my parents treated me.
- ☐ God has loved me with an everlasting love.
- ☐ The Lord receives me.
- ☐ God settles the lonely in families.
- ☐ I am a child of God.
- ☐ I can receive love now.

In my own words: _____

4 My Scripture

The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.

- ☐ Psalm 27:10
  "Though my father and mother forsake me, the LORD will receive me."
- ☐ Jeremiah 31:3
  "The LORD appeared to us in the past, saying: 'I have loved you with an everlasting love; therefore I have drawn you with loving devotion.'"
- ☐ 1 John 3:1
  "Behold what manner of love the Father has given to us, that we should be called children of God. And that is what we are! The reason the world does not know us is that it did not know Him."

A verse I found myself: _____

Practicing the Truth

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5 My practice plan

Everyone does the first four. Then pick one or two extra tools.

EVERYONE DOES THESE

- ☐ Make my Truth Card (below). Carry it and read it at least three times a day.
- ☐ Memorize my Scripture from Step 4.
- ☐ Listen to one song each day from "Songs that speak truth to this belief" on my card, and fill in my song journal (below).
- ☐ Set reminders to silently repeat my truth. Check one or more:
  - ☐ A buzz: my watch or phone vibrates every _____ minutes
  - ☐ An everyday event: every time I _____
  - ☐ A visual reminder: something I will see often, such as a sticky note on my mirror, my truth as the background picture on my phone, or a note on my car dashboard.

PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- ☐ Love received: Each day, write one way you received love or kindness from God or from another person.
- ☐ My name in Scripture: Write a personal reminder based on my verse and read it aloud. Keep this application separate from the Bible quotation.

  For example, Psalm 27:10 becomes: "Sarah can write: "Even if my parents failed me, the Lord receives me.""
- ☐ Gratitude journal: Each night, write three things I thank God for.
- ☐ Truth recording: Record my own voice reading my Truth Card and verse, and listen in the car or on a walk.
- ☐ Reading: The "Love, By God" topic in Pearls.
- ☐ Listening: The Overcoming Depression audio by Dr. Brian Campbell. Tap to play.

6 My action step this week

Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.

Choose steps you can do safely. If there is violence, coercion, or fear of retaliation, seek private professional support before trying anything with the other person. In an emergency call 911.

- ☐ Write the story honestly. Describe what you experienced and what you concluded as a child. Pray over it.
- ☐ Grieve what you missed. Allow sadness for what you did not receive, with a trusted listener if possible.
- ☐ Name people who love you. List three people or communities who care for you now.
- ☐ Read 1 John 3:1 aloud. Say it each morning for a week.

What I will do: _____

When: _____

What the lie predicts will happen: _____

7 End-of-week check-in

Bring this page to your next session.

What actually happened: _____

_____

What I learned: _____

The lie "My parents never loved me": _____ % My truth: _____ %

Daily practice tracker

Day	Read my card	Said my verse	Used my reminder	Love received
Mon				
Tue				
Wed				
Thu				
Fri				
Sat				
Sun				

My song journal

After each day's song, write what it told you that challenges the lie.

Day	Song I listened to	What it told me that challenges the lie
Mon		
Tue		
Wed		
Thu		
Fri		
Sat		
Sun		

My Truth Card

THE LIE

~~My parents never loved me.~~

THE TRUTH

GOD'S WORD

Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.

Prayer

Father, You see the places where I did not feel loved. Receive me, heal what was hurt, and let me know that I am Your child. Bring people into my life who show Your love. Amen.

Scripture quotations are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB), which is in the public domain.